

**No More Stargazing**

In a new update, Google has puzzlingly taken away wide-angle astrophotography from Pixel 5 and 4a 5G. <http://digit.in/jan21-61>

**Glance**

Google invests in Indian startup - Glance, which serves news, movies and games on phone lockscreens. <http://digit.in/jan21-62>



MOUNTAIN STARTUPS

A number of startups associated with the Naropa Fellowship are addressing issues in an ecologically and culturally sensitive way

Aditya Madanapalle |
aditya@digit.in

The Naropa Fellowship is a leadership program nestled in the heart of the Himalayas, at Hemis in Ladakh. The goal of the program is to empower the local entrepreneurial youth with the knowledge and skills necessary to come up with innovative solutions for the problems faced in the region, while preserving the cultural heritage. The curriculum consists of courses as diverse as design, tourism, philosophy and behavioral sciences. A number of interesting startups associated with the program have sprung up in the mountains, and we interacted with them to better

understand how specific problems are being addressed. These startups are environmentally conscious, leverage technology, use resources from the mountains, try to preserve or even revive local forms of art, and create jobs for locals in the region.

LADAKH LOCAL IS AN ECOMMERCE PLATFORM FOR TRADITIONAL ARTISANS

One of the first things we wanted to understand was why the big e-commerce players find it hard to work in the mountains. A spokesperson for Ladakh Local explains, “the high altitude region of Ladakh faces tremendous challenges with regards to accessibility, network and logistics on account of its rugged terrain and remote location. Most of the e-commerce giants like Amazon serve

only the town city of Leh and some regions in the vicinity for a period of 4-6 months. Local e-commerce platforms are springing up in Leh and they receive tremendous support from the inhabitants. The terrain knowledge and local liaisons helps the locals build a brand and capitalise on the limited resources. This knowledge hasn't been tapped by the e-commerce giants yet.”

The focus of the startup is to make sure that the local artisans get a fair deal in online marketplaces, by removing as many middlemen as possible. There is also an effort to revive dying forms of traditional art, including metalwork and pottery. When asked how the platform is different from other e-commerce portals, “Ladakh Local, endeavors to be an online marketplace for indigenous handmade products of the Himalayan region, particularly Ladakh. Most of the e-commerce platforms in the market deal with items of mass consumption, machine made products or handmade products of the